

Competitor Launch Playbook — How the mystery-box brands started their socials

Compiled 2026-07-28. What IcyBox, Courtyard, Cases.gg, PackDraw (+ HypeDrop, RillaBox) actually did with their FIRST social content and launch. Honest constraint: the literal "first 10 posts" per platform are NOT retrievable from the open web (TikTok/IG/X/YouTube 403 automated access and show newest-first; archive.org is blocked here). The Apify inputs (`competitor_firstposts_*`) pull each profile's full history so we can sort oldest-first and get the exact first 10 — run those for the literal list. Below is what IS knowable: launch dates, earliest-content DNA, and the launch strategy each used.

The four archetypes (the useful pattern)

Every one of these launched with **one of two engines**, plus a shared content DNA:

- **A) Founder / creator front-man** — a personality posts the "day zero" announcement and lends credibility (PackDraw's DOOM13, IcyBox's Ted Park).
 - **B) Audience inheritance** — launch off an existing community you already own (Cases.gg off Clash.gg; Courtyard off its 2021 NFT/Discord base).
 - **Shared earliest-content DNA: big-pull reveal/reaction clips + giveaways + promo codes** — never polished ads. Plus a **trust line from post #1** (odds upfront / instant buyback / fulfillment proof).
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PackDraw — founder-led, giveaway + big-pull engine

- **Day zero:** founder **DOOM13** announced it from his **personal X (@DoomisGod), Aug 2, 2023** — a "year and a half in the making" reveal — *then* propagated to the brand handle. Dev implied since ~2022.
 - **Earliest content DNA: X giveaways** (follow + RT + tag friends for \$100–\$250 cash/pack credit) + **big-pull hype clips** (screen-recorded openings landing high-value cards, e.g. a ~\$550k sealed box pulled from a ~\$600 pack). A separate **@PackDrawClaims** account posted fulfillment proof ("\$3M+ fulfilled") — trust as content.
 - **Note:** the SteveWillDolt deal was **mid-2025 (growth phase), NOT launch**. They started small and founder-authentic, not with a mega-creator.
 - Now IG ~102K; corporate = PackDraw Ltd (Cyprus) + PackDraw US LLC (Delaware).
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IcyBox — TikTok-first, rapper front-man, watch-pull reactions

- **Day zero:** built around **Ted Park (@tedparkboi)** — a Korean-American rapper running "marketing & partnerships @icyboxapp," promo code **ICYTED**. Launch post: "If you told me 6 months ago I'd launch the first lootbox app for watches..."* (iOS conceived ~Oct 2025; X joined Jan 2026; Google Play Mar 2026).
 - **Earliest content DNA: watch-pull reaction/reveal videos** ("I almost crashed out from this pull"), **themed limited boxes** as hooks (e.g. "The Independence Box," \$250 → Rolex Meteorite / Omega / TAG), **free-watch giveaways tied to app downloads**, creator promo codes, and an **IRL Coachella activation** (handing out watches on camera).
 - **Platform priority: TikTok (~148K) dwarfs everything**; X is an afterthought (~310). This is the closest analog to a modern, from-zero, TikTok-first launch.
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Cases.gg — audience inheritance (the shortcut)

- **Day zero:** site live **Aug 15, 2024**, run by **CGG Entertainment** — **the same operator as Clash.gg**, so it launched **off Clash.gg's existing CS2/skins community**, not from zero. This is the biggest

single launch advantage of the four.

- **Content DNA:** high-cadence **promo-code drops** on X, **provably-fair / blockchain-verifiable** trust messaging, **luxury-prize aspiration** (Patek Nautilus, Lamborghini Urus), and **case-battle** clips.
- Handles (corrected): X @casesdotgg (~23.4K) · IG @cases_dotgg (~5.3K), TikTok @cases.gg.

Courtyard — the two-phase pivot (NFT base → consumer rip content)

- **Phase 1 (2021–2023):** launched as a crypto/NFT project — **Twitter + Discord**, presale/whitelist spots, "physically-backed NFT" narrative, PR partnerships (**Brink's, OpenSea, YC W2022, Chainlink**). Community-and-PR-led, not reveal-content-led.
- **Phase 2 (Mar 2024 →):** re-launched for the mainstream with the ****Vending Machine** (TikTok post Mar 21, 2024)** — *"rip Pokémon packs... \$25 packs on-demand... instant buyback... odds upfront. Click, rip, repeat."* Pivoted to **pack-ripping demo content + creator seeding** (@100charizards etc.), code **TIKTOKPACK**, and **odds-upfront / instant-buyback** trust framing.
- **IG ~89K is its biggest channel; TikTok ~4.5K.** Raised **\$37.5M**. Heavy press (Forbes, Polygon, PH).

HypeDrop & RillaBox (secondary)

- **HypeDrop:** launched **Jan 8, 2019** in the sneaker/streetwear box niche (amid the Jake Paul/RiceGum "MysteryBrand" scandal era); shut V1 down Mar 2024, **relaunched V2** Aug/Sep 2024.
- **RillaBox (~2021): community-first** — a 50K+ Discord, daily challenges/races/badges, ****referral-code** virality **and** user unboxing UGC** as the growth loop, rather than streamer seeding. IG @rillaboxofficial.

What GemBreak should copy for next week's launch

1. **Use BOTH engines you have** — a founder **"day zero" post** (Avery's story, like DOOM13/Ted Park) **AND audience inheritance** (the 414K YouTube channel + Atlas creator network). Most competitors had only one.
 1. **First posts = big-pull reveal clips + a giveaway + promo codes**, not a polished ad. Seed 5–8 creators with codes on day one (your golf bench: Rick Shiels / Good Good / Bob Does Sports).
 1. **Lead with trust from post #1** — "odds upfront, transparent buyback, fulfillment proof." This is your wedge (IcyBox's #1 complaint is opaque valuations; you show the number). Stand up a "GemBreak Claims"-style fulfillment-proof account like PackDraw did.
 1. **TikTok-first** (IcyBox proved the from-zero TikTok path: 148K there vs 310 on X), + the clipping engine.
 2. **A launch stunt** — IcyBox's Coachella-style IRL giveaway is a repeatable spike; do a golf-world version (a course/Topgolf activation or a grail giveaway).
 1. **A giveaway mechanic** (follow + tag / free-pack-on-signup) to farm the first followers fast.

Get the LITERAL first 10 (run these)

`scraper_inputs/competitor_firstposts_tiktok_input.json` (clockworks/tiktok-scraper, full history) + `scraper_inputs/competitor_firstposts_ig_input.json` (apify/instagram-scraper, corrected handles). They pull each profile's full post history; send me the JSON and I'll ****sort oldest-first and hand back the exact first 10 posts per brand**** with caption, date, format, and view/like counts. Verify TikTok handles in-app first (icybox, cases.gg vary), and bump `resultsPerPage` / `resultsLimit` if a brand has >300 posts.